



**2009 WAS A  
WATERSHED  
YEAR. DEMAND  
OVERTOOK SUPPLY  
AS THE TOP 1 PER  
CENT SPLURGED  
ON LUXURY CARS.**

world stage with their posh cars.

But the classic Mercedes is no longer the symbol of wealth as yuppie CEOs and second-generation entrepreneurs are opting for sportier and aggressive brands like BMW and Audi. With sales of 3,619 in 2009, BMW has displaced market leader Mercedes from its leadership position. With total sales of 3,247 cars compared to last year's 3,625, Mercedes has to recover lost market-share. Says Peter Kronschnabl, CEO of BMW India: "In absolute terms, India cannot compete with other high-volume single markets, but the future belongs to India."

So if you have the passion for wheels, the world's marquee brands are rolling out the red carpet. Of the four new vehicles unveiled by the BMW at the Auto Expo in January 2010, the company is launching the limited edition of the new BMW Gran

Turismo. Only an elite 100 will get to own this beauty, priced attractively at Rs 63 lakh. Other launches include the BMW X6 M, priced at Rs 1.3 crore, and the new BMW 760Li at Rs 1.29 crore. If limited edition vehicles excite you, then BMW isn't the only one offering such exclusivity to 100 consumers. To mark Audi's 100-year celebrations, the company has announced a Limited Edition Audi A6 2.7 TDI, which will be available for Rs 37 lakh.

With Audi and BMW snapping at its heels, the pioneer of luxury vehicles in India, Mercedes Benz, has also lined up an array of next generation cars. For those who have written off Mercedes as the big daddy brand must catch the yet-to-be launched M-Class 'Luxury Edition', and the new E-Coupe. Says Dr Wilfried Aulbur, CEO of Mercedes-Benz India: "We see a situation in India where young professionals want to acquire the best while

they are young, and facilitating this is the easy finance scheme."

Automakers are doing all they can to lure the conspicuous consumers in India. From wine and whisky tasting sessions in car showrooms to golf tournaments, these brands are catching the consumer on the go. On target are not just big cities but Tier II cities like Jaipur, Ahmedabad and Surat, where sales of luxury cars are booming. BMW, which opened a dealership in Jaipur three months ago, has already sold 30 cars. Even Audi is promising to offer its full line in India by 2015. Despite being number three player here in terms of volume, India is part of Audi's goal of selling 1.5 million vehicles in total by 2015. With sales of 1,658 cars in 2009 compared to 349 cars in 2007, the target looks like a cakewalk.

Clearly, the hunger for posh wheels has just started in India. And with players like BMW India applying for a non-banking finance company (NBFC) licence, soon retail consumers will be able to lease a Beemer for Rs 60,000 for three years and return it for a new vehicle. To expand the market to include new customers, BMW is launching X1 later this year, which will be priced at Rs 25 lakh to create a whole new segment. This is clearly one market which will see plenty of action. ■